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Utilities ordered to trim gas bills

But will be allowed to make up for cut later

By Jon Chesto and Dana Gerber
GLOBE STAFF

Responding to an outcry among consumers and elected officials, the Massachusetts Department of Public Utilities ordered the state's five natural gas utilities to reduce average residential gas bills by at least 5 percent in March and April.

But to some critics, the modest reduction comes across as too little and too late — in part because the utilities will be able to recoup the money later in the year, during the warmer months.

The DPU faced pressure from members of the Legislature and from Governor Maura Healey after many Massachusetts residents experienced sticker shock from heating bills that soared as the weather turned much colder this winter.

For Marisa Palumbo, the latest gas bill from Eversource for her three-bedroom home in

BILLS, Page A7

Salem State strives to serve Latino students

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

SALEM — Tucked in corners around Salem State University are signs of change: Admissions tours not just in English, but in Spanish, Portuguese, and soon, Haitian Creole. Plantains and yuca fries alongside the usual American fare in the dining hall. And posters on the front door of the administrative building on Lafayette Street advertising “Café y Tertulia,” a coffee hour where staffers can brush up on their language skills.

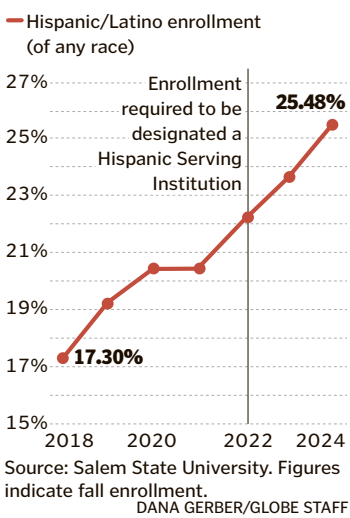
They are all small but measurable steps Salem State has taken to live up to its status as the first public four-year “Hispanic Serving Institution” in Massachusetts, a federal designation for universities where at least a quarter of students are Latino. Salem State watched its Latino enrollment tick up naturally for at least a decade, but officially passed the threshold to become an HSI in October, setting it up to join 12 other officially designated “minority-serving institutions” in Massachusetts.

The designation opens universities to receive federal funding that aims to help students of

SALEM STATE, Page A6

Racial breakdown of Salem State students

The ranks of Hispanic or Latino students at the university surpassed 25 percent for the first time last year.



‘There’s no provision in TPS law that allows the administration to **revoke an extension.**’

OREN SELLSTROM, *Lawyers for Civil Rights*

More challenges to immigration limits

Amid funding freeze, N.E. farmers left waiting for promised payments

By Amanda Gokee
GLOBE STAFF

CONCORD, N.H. — With a payment of around \$4,000 from a federal grant in limbo, Stephanie Kelliher isn’t sure if she’ll be able to finish installing a new irrigation system on her small farm in Whitefield, N.H.

She’s already drilled the well at Uphill Farm, and installed a pump and pumping plant, but when federal agents came to check her progress in late January, she learned her payment was among the funds frozen by the Trump administration.

“This drip irrigation system was going to be super efficient and was going to save me so much time and energy,” she said in an email. She said the project would allow her to water her plants more effectively, increase her yields, and help the plants better withstand pests.

But in late January, the Trump administration issued a memo ordering a freeze on funding for thousands of federal

FARMERS, Page A6

HOLD ON NIH CUTS EXTENDED

The Trump administration plan to slash medical research funding has been sharply criticized by scientists. **B1.**

ANOTHER FIRING IN WASHINGTON

President Trump abruptly fired Air Force General CQ Brown as chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. **A2.**

Ending protections for Venezuelan, Haitian migrants has familiar ring

By Sean Cotter and Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio
GLOBE STAFF

President Trump’s recent moves to end temporary protections for immigrants from Venezuela and Haiti are expected to revive a legal battle from his first term when he tried, unsuccessfully, to revoke similar legal permissions for migrants.

Immigrant advocates on Friday were gearing up for a protracted court fight after Trump announced he would end what is known as Temporary Protected Status, or TPS, for roughly a half-million Haitians in August, including about 4,700 in Massachusetts who are now scrambling for options in the face of deportation proceedings that could begin in a matter of months.

The challenge could hinge in part on the unprecedented decision by the administration to cut short an extension of TPS for Haitian immigrants to February 2026 that was put in place by the Biden administration. Those protections for Hai-

HAITIANS, Page A7



FROZEN WONDERLAND

Visitors to Ice Castles in North Woodstock, N.H., can wander among towering ice structures nestled against the snow-covered White Mountains. The castles require thousands of hours of meticulous craftsmanship, with artisans daily harvesting and hand-sculpting up to 12,000 individual icicles into the display. Come spring, these 25 million pounds of glistening ice will melt back into the adjacent natural waterway. Above, a visitor explored among the towers. The structures display a natural blue hue that’s created when white light hits the dense ice, which absorbs all the other colors. At right, an ice cavern was lit with purple light. **B2.**



PHOTOS BY ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

‘War over the cancer dollar’

Behind the scenes, Mass General Brigham fights Dana-Farber’s proposed hospital

By Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

A fight over the future of cancer care is playing out in a behind-the-scenes battle over Dana-Farber Cancer Institute’s proposed new hospital, underscoring the intense stakes in the business breakup between two of the state’s most prominent health care brands.

Dana-Farber has proposed building a \$1.7 billion, 300-bed cancer center as it severs its longstanding partnership with Brigham and Women’s, which provides in-hospital care for Dana-Farber patients.

But the acrimonious split between the two storied institutions took another turn when a new report from the state revealed that Brigham’s corporate parent, Mass General Brigham, has been lobbying against the Dana-Farber project, saying it is

Dana-Farber’s proposals call for a **688,100**-square-foot inpatient hospital on the campus of Beth Israel Deaconess Medical Center, jointly staffed with Beth Israel and largely overseen by Dana-Farber.

unnecessary, too big, and would raise health care spending in the state.

In its report, the Department of Public Health largely sided with Dana-Farber, recommending the cancer hospital for approval and dismissing many of Mass General Brigham’s concerns. The department’s Public Health Council will consider the report when it votes on the project March 20, a critical approval necessary for it to move forward.

The flings show just how contentious the split between Dana-Farber and Mass General Brigham has become, and hints at more strife to follow as the project moves toward final sign-offs from key state agencies.

“In most of the country, it’s a war against cancer. Here, it’s a war over the cancer dollar,” said Paul Hattis, a senior fellow at the

HOSPITALS, Page A10



Rushdie’s attacker is found guilty

Jurors, who deliberated less than two hours, said Hadi Matar was guilty of attempted murder. **A2.**

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu vowed revenge for what he described as a “cruel and malicious violation” of the cease-fire agreement after authorities determined that a body released by Hamas was not an Israeli mother of two small boys, as the militant group had promised. **A4.**

Several vehicles were damaged after a section of concrete suddenly fell onto Interstate 90 in the Prudential Tunnel, causing a major backup. **B1.**

Dunkin’ said it will no longer charge extra for non-dairy creamer alternatives, such as oat milk or almond milk. **D1.**



Bright on time

Saturday: Sunny, warmer. High: 36-41. Low: 25-30.

Sunday: Partly sunny. High: 37-42. Low: 23-28.

Comics and Weather, **D4-5.** Obituaries, **C9.**

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